



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 16

# INDIANA

## WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

*Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Indiana's family courts and child-welfare system.*

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# 70

INDIANA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 105  
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 18 MONTHS  
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING  
TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 6, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

35 OF 92

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

# INDIANA AT A GLANCE.

Across 70 Indiana families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

|                                                                                                |                                                                                                                  |                                                                          |                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div>CHILDREN IMPACTED</div> <div>105</div> <div>69 of 70 families reported child counts</div> | <div>MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN</div> <div>\$56,250</div> <div>median across 33 families reporting 3+ categories</div> | <div>MEDIAN MONTHS LOST</div> <div>18</div> <div>of parenting time</div> | <div>WENT PRO SE</div> <div>42.9%</div> <div>32.9% after running out of money</div> |
| <div>SUBMISSIONS</div> <div>70</div>                                                           | <div>AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY</div> <div>1.5</div>                                                                  | <div>FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN</div> <div>69 of 70</div>               | <div>COUNTIES REPRESENTED</div> <div>35</div>                                       |

## WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Indiana families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF INDIANA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

| EXPENSE CATEGORY                                           | RESPONSES | MEDIAN   | MEAN     | TOTAL REPORTED |
|------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|----------|----------|----------------|
| Attorney Fees                                              | 50        | \$10,000 | \$35,384 | \$1,769,200    |
| Lost Wages                                                 | 38        | \$6,000  | \$62,484 | \$2,374,401    |
| Other Court Fees                                           | 25        | \$100    | \$2,096  | \$52,400       |
| Therapy / Evaluations                                      | 29        | \$1,500  | \$18,559 | \$538,200      |
| Reunification Services                                     | 25        | \$0      | \$10,720 | \$268,000      |
| GAL Fees                                                   | 31        | \$250    | \$9,571  | \$296,700      |
| Asset Loss                                                 | 36        | \$13,000 | \$94,397 | \$3,398,300    |
| Median Family Burden (33 families reporting 3+ categories) | —         | \$56,250 | —        | —              |

**Median vs. mean:** Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS



## 03 WHO IS REPORTING · INDIANA

Most families documenting in Indiana are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

## CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

## CASE STATUS

|                                    |                                                                                   |    |     |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|-----|
| Active case: stuck or delayed      |  | 28 | 40% |
| Case closed: within last 2 years   |  | 19 | 27% |
| Not provided                       |  | 12 | 17% |
| Case closed: more than 2 years ago |  | 5  | 7%  |
| Active case: progress being made   |  | 3  | 4%  |

## SYSTEM AFFECTED

|                                      |                                                                                     |    |     |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|-----|
| Both Family Court and CPS            |  | 33 | 47% |
| Family Court Only                    |  | 23 | 33% |
| CPS (Child Protective Services) Only |  | 10 | 14% |
| Unknown                              |  | 3  | 4%  |
| Family Court                         |  | 1  | 1%  |

## DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

## TIME IN SYSTEM

|                   |                                                                                     |    |     |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|-----|
| 1 – 3 years       |  | 17 | 24% |
| 5 – 10 years      |  | 12 | 17% |
| 6 months – 1 year |  | 12 | 17% |
| 3 – 5 years       |  | 12 | 17% |
| Over 10 years     |  | 8  | 11% |

## CUSTODY STATUS

|                                   |                                                                                       |    |     |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|-----|
| Visitation Only                   |  | 21 | 30% |
| No Contact / Total Loss of Access |  | 16 | 23% |
| Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)   |  | 8  | 11% |
| Full Custody                      |  | 8  | 11% |
| 50/50 Joint                       |  | 8  | 11% |

## GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

## TOP COUNTIES

|             |                                                                                     |   |     |
|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|-----|
| Marion      |  | 8 | 11% |
| Allen       |  | 5 | 7%  |
| Vanderburgh |  | 3 | 4%  |
| Jennings    |  | 2 | 3%  |
| Hamilton    |  | 2 | 3%  |
| Clark       |  | 2 | 3%  |

## TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

|                                                                             |                                                                                       |    |     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|-----|
| Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)         |  | 23 | 33% |
| False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report) |  | 14 | 20% |
| Other: (Short answer)                                                       |  | 9  | 13% |
| High Conflict Divorce                                                       |  | 8  | 11% |
| Medical CPS (Medical Child Abuse allegations, disagreement with doctors)    |  | 4  | 6%  |

## 04 PARENT VOICES — INDIANA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Indiana comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



*It's terrified my children ripped my marriage apart, made us scared that if we don't immediately take our kids to the doctor with every bump and fall and scrape that they will come back and try to remove gave us fear of our own local public. Servants has caused our children [...]*

— DEVIN

## ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

The system has put my children in the hands of the abuser. The judge completely ignored the evidence.

— INDIANA PARENT · MICHELLE

## MORE VOICES FROM INDIANA

Procedural failures and biased reporting—especially in documentation—led to a narrative that misrepresented me and negatively impacted my family. Instead of protecting stability, the system introduced confusion, delay, and unnecessary harm. The process became more about [...]

— EVA

It's destroyed me and my children and the bond we had

— JAMIE

Trauma PTSD due to removal all 5 children and my self major depression and my 5 year old is a self harmer. They destroyed a beautiful family left us in ruins.

— NICHOLE

The heartache sometimes is unbearable I had five kids always something going on .to nothing but silence worst thing in the world I will ever go thru

— MAVEN

Destroyed it & then caused same harm on 2 of the kids they wanted to blame me for.

— AMY

It has destroyed is mentally, physically, emotionally, and it has taken away time we could have shared together.

— DEONDA

## 04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*The system destroyed my family. When parents need both parents they favored one! Sure I made a mistake but to pay for the mistake for years and years. Even after I did all classes that was asked of me. I went from primary custody parent to only 5 hours every Sunday. I went from [...]*

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Completely destroyed and tore my family apart. 3 kids all in 3 diff homes. All kids now dealing with mental health issues and separation issues

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has destroyed the relationships I've spent 16yrs building. I have been permanently injured/nearly killed and after 4yrs without contact 2 out of 4 people that I woke to still having here on earth don't call or even send a happy birthday message. I've spent everything [...]

— BILL

Through the CHINS process, DCS has not only disrupted our family but has inflicted lasting emotional, spiritual, and financial strain, challenging our rights as parents and our ability to nurture our children in a safe, loving, and faith-centered environment

— KARI

The info I provided is just the tip of the ice berg. There is so much more. We have been ripped apart as a family. Little sisters once close torn apart never to see each other again. We are traumatized. Depressed. No one cares. No one will listen. No one will help.

— CRYSTAL

DESTROYED IT, my son doesn't even respond to myself or his grandparents and any of my family

— CHRISTOPHER

Traumatized us. Let an abusive sadistic man maintain control.

— KIM

These people have tore my kids away from loving parents only to scuritize and defamate me and my wife

— BRANDON

Destroyed us caused alot of issues had to quit my job to homeschool my kids they were trying their hardest to take my kids from me for no reason

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

## 04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*They stole my 3 kids and lied about it. Adopted them out.*

— RALPH

They kidnapped 3 of my granddaughters, traumatized them and adopted 2 of them out, and gave the baby back after a year and a half. The 6 year old does not understand why she got adopted but her baby sister got to come home. They ripped our family apart.

— JOYCE

Destroyed my family and our future. My son isn't the same . Ruined my credit my reputation tried to cost me my retirement even.

— KATRINA

Traumatized, isolated my child from family.

— CHASITY

destroyed us made us resent eachother and the system went into deep depression made us spiral downhill since hearing

— JENNIFER

This system has destroyed my family. My relationship with my son is being harmed.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Striped my children and myself of the love and bond with a sibling and son.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

After a long and abusive marriage of 12 years my ex wife leveled piles of false alligations against me which were never sustained as they never happened. At 7 years post divorce I am still being held below guidelines time with my children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

As the primary parent who raised the children the heaviness of grief it has caused to the children and myself is difficult to describe. The children did not deserve to be placed in the unsafe environment with a parent who signed off their rights.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

## 04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*Ruined our family bond made father out to be a villain my daughters think we can't protect them and don't love them mother has disabilities and can't see her kids they are her entire world. Since I am the leader of the family they have told my girls I don't love them and can't [...]*

— CHRIS

This system is failing to protect a little girl who simply does not have a voice. While simultaneously encouraging our abuser to sabotage a future before its even started. My daughter just turned 3 and a half.

— ISAAC

Ex used old therapy messages without disclosing to opposing counsel as evidence of substance abuse, but there weren't any. I took 2 90 day hair follicle tests to debunk his allegations, and the judge seemed to just ignore my proof. Daughter complained of her grandmother abusing [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Separated my children and caused them to have emotional issues

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Made things worse then what they were

— CASEY

Shattered completely. Girls fear punishment for association....even tho they grown. Dad is money supply.

— SHELBY

Indiana dcs has robbed my children of what could have been a happy, normal childhood and rendered us gagged, bound, helpless and alone. The only protection my children needed was from the Department of Child Services.

— EMILY

Robbed us of our rely and memories. Broken out bond and ruined out emotional and mental health effects our future relationships.

— SUZI

The system stole my entire soul from me, my first baby, the little girl who made me a mom. And gave my abuser power through lies and manipulation.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT



## 04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*It has changed me on a molecular level, I am sicker now than I ever have been and I'm watching my children misunderstood why their mother isn't present like she was.*

— KAYLE

Turned my kids against me.

— LIZA

Took away my rights as a mother time away from my son time spending with him cost me thousands asking the same thing over and over again. chose an abusive parent that now has custody.

— AMBER

The system showed me that the court system as a whole is extensively flawed. The system is a popularity contest of who knows who; not justice.

— MARRINA

The judge even called me a deadbeat 10 years being divorced 9 years 50/50 until we switch judges and now I'm a deadbeat dad all due to lies and yes I've got the proof

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The Guardian ad Litem, Sybil Sharvelle, appears to have been brainwashed by the father and claimed the mother is psychologically abusing the child after the child disclosed sexual abuse by the father for the second time and a PO was issued by a preponderance of the evidence by [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Traumatized use and used my son as a test subject the cause mental harm stress and broke us. My son may only live 5 years with is conditions and they stole 6 months we will never get back

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has ruined my family, deprived me of my rights and taught me that money talks more than the truth. It has taught me that under civil law there is no right to counsel as there is under criminal law.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It put me through mental and emotional hell.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

54 Indiana parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 44 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

**05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — INDIANA**

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Indiana families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

The system has put my children in the hands of the abuser. The judge completely ignored the evidence.

— MICHELLE

It's terrified my children ripped my marriage apart, made us scared that if we don't immediately take our kids to the doctor with every bump and fall and scrape that they will come back and try to remove gave us fear of our own local public. Servants has caused our children great mental trauma has shut down even with years of therapy is still not better.

— DEVIN

Procedural failures and biased reporting—especially in documentation—led to a narrative that misrepresented me and negatively impacted my family. Instead of protecting stability, the system introduced confusion, delay, and unnecessary harm. The process became more about compliance than fairness, with real-life impacts overlooked. The process is ongoing and escalating, deteriorating my relationship with my children. No due process, defamation of character, false allegations, frivolous motions filed statistically every 2 weeks for 5 years, stole my transportation during co-parenting counseling, lost job at post office, smear campaign, unilateral decisions, parental alienation, third party interference, falsifying documents, corrupt, corrupt, corrupt

— EVA

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— DEONDA

The system destroyed my family. When parents need both parents they favored one! Sure I made a mistake but to pay for the mistake for years and years. Even after I did all classes that was asked of me. I went from primary custody parent to only 5 hours every Sunday. I went from receiving 112 a week in support to paying \$800 a month in support. My ex abused the court orders. Gave me visits based on if he felt I deserved visits. I tried to inform the gal she ignored me. The gal only visited my ex home and spoke with ex witnesses. Never visited my home or spoke with my witnesses. She ignored that I completed all my courses. My attorney never spoke up in court when asked if I completed the courses.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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This system has destroyed the relationships I've spent 16yrs building. I have been permanently injured/nearly killed and after 4yrs without contact 2 out of 4 people that I woke to still having here on earth don't call or even send a happy birthday message. I've spent everything I earned in 50 yrs and retirement trying to find someone that would simply read the black and white to no avail. Now to top it all after losing my fiancé, father, grandmother, and my only 2 daughters along with my ability to walk I'm going to be put in prison over child support when I have never been behind until the wreck where I was nearly killed. My children, reputation, everything I've bought and paid for has been stolen while in jail or sold to get out. My home will be the last thing I lose along with my freedom here in three weeks.

— BILL

**05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

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Ruined our family bond made father out to be a villain my daughters think we can't protect them and don't love them mother has disabilities and can't see her kids they are her entire world. Since I am the leader of the family they have told my girls I don't love them and can't protect them constant threats and retaliation and I was forced to get my own place simply to put my children in foster care 5 hrs away and not giving me proper notice complete nightmare deny me from giving my daughters attention she needs after suicide attempts and not properly notifying me of events

— CHRIS

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— ISAAC

Ex used old therapy messages without disclosing to opposing counsel as evidence of substance abuse, but there weren't any. I took 2 90 day hair follicle tests to debunk his allegations, and the judge seemed to just ignore my proof. Daughter complained of her grandmother abusing her (she lives with the ex now), and I had filed with CPS. They unsubstantiated the allegation, even after a forensic interview where the child clearly stated what happened.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Made things worse then what they were

— CASEY

**05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have lost precious time with my child because of delays and negligence. Numerous hearings ignored for me and granted for ex wife that cost my relationship with my son unmeasurably.

— JEFF



**05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

Taken so much precious time my kids lost with me that we can never get back. Scarred the kids in seeing that the courts truly did not care about their best interest and let us down over and over.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Inflicted nothing but harm, pain, and ensured future issues to be processed in the future. This system torn us apart for no known reason and continues to steal money from my family while boosting the growing three million the state makes from support.

— JIM

It is a well-documented systematic network of people profiting off perpetuating the endless nightmare of abuse from my ex-husband and aiding in the slow public murder of myself and family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Make me take parenting classes, sych. Test, on probation, threatening me with jail, take all my money. I have deep depression to the point of thinking about suicide

— ANTHONY

The family court system has allowed my ex to abuse me post-separation via expensive litigation, delaying necessary services for our son who is struggling and has ignored every piece of evidence brought into the court room. The system has failed my child.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have lost immeasurable time and experiences with my boy, ultimately losing my identity. I have had to turn down jobs, career paths, dreams, emotional connections with so many people who don't understand what I have gone through.

— JEFF

**05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

Created diversion, chaos, and emotionally trashed my family, sat back and watched the diversion they created... And used it for their own financial gain.

— MICHAEL

It has damaged me and my family. My oldest son has been taken from us all. He has a younger brother who talks about him daily. Who wishes he could see his brother and wonders why it has happened. It's affected him in ways we can't help 😞.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has completely made distrust with the system, the law is scared of the word family law. Allen County is a County where people help the abuse. My son's dad was allowed to come after my daughters. Everyone keeps saying this doesn't involve them. But the hurt and loss of losing a sibling the most disgusting way. We have to watch wear we go or we get attacked from the abuser. My whole family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

54 full approved Indiana comments are included in this appendix.

## 06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

### WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Indiana report comes from Indiana respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Indiana — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

### WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 70 Indiana families reporting here are not the universe of Indiana families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

### METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through [standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey](https://standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey). Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

### ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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